rebels. However, their initial efforts at unseating the Nanda king of Magadh appear to have failed. There is a legend that tells of how Chandragupta had to flee into the forests to escape the Nanda king. Overcome with fatigue he collapsed and fell into a deep slumber. However, a lion appeared and licked him clean. Then it stood guard till the future king awoke. When Chandragupta realized what had happened, he saw it as a good omen and renewed his efforts to unseat the Nandas. The story may have been spread by later Mauryan propagandists but, yet again, it emphasizes the symbolic importance of the lion.

After several years of effort, Chanakya managed to cobble together a large army, possibly with the help of the hill tribes of Himachal. He and Chandragupta slowly took control of the north-west of the country. Then they steadily encroached into the Gangetic plains. Around 321 BC, they defeated the Nanda king of Magadh and emerged as the paramount power in the subcontinent. Astonishingly, Chanakya did not take the throne for himself but crowned his pupil. Then they spent over a decade establishing control over central India.

By around 305 BC, Chandragupta felt confident enough to directly confront the Macedonians. One of Alexander's most talented generals, Seleucus Nikator, was in control of the conqueror's Asian domains, including Persia and Central Asia. He also laid claim to the Indian territories conquered by Alexander. However, judging from the terms of a treaty between the two in 303 BC, the Mauryan army decisively won the war. Chandragupta gained control over Balochistan and Afghanistan. Seleucus also gave his daughter in marriage to a Mauryan prince, perhaps Chandragupta himself.

For three generations, the Mauyran empire would cover the whole subcontinent from the edge of eastern Iran to what is now Bangladesh. Only the southernmost tip of India would remain outside its direct control. At its height, it was the largest and most populous empire in the world, dwarfing both Alexander's domains and those of Shi Huangdi in China. Furthermore, unlike the empires of Alexander and the first Chinese empire, the Mauyran empire lasted at least three generations as a complete unit.